CULTURAL INNOVATION LAB

Innovation Readiness Action Plan

From Assessment to Action

A practical workbook for cultural entrepreneurs who have completed the Cultural Innovation Readiness Assessment (CIRA). Turn your scores into a concrete 90-day plan that builds the capabilities your enterprise needs to thrive.

- 90-day action plans for each CIRA dimension
- Barrier prioritisation matrix and resource mapping
- Skill gap analysis and training planner
- Cultural appropriation risk assessment
- Weekly milestone tracker and check-in templates

2025-2026 Edition
For use alongside the CIL platform assessments

Contents

1 How to Use This Action Plan
2 90-Day Action Plans by Dimension
a) Cultural Capital Inventory
b) Innovation Ecosystem
c) Barriers Assessment
d) Readiness Indicators
3 Barrier Prioritisation Matrix
4 Resource Mapping Worksheet
5 Skill Gap Analysis & Training Planner
6 Cultural Appropriation Risk Assessment
7 Milestone Tracker

This is a working document. Print it, write in it, mark it up, and revisit it every quarter. The best plan is one that has coffee stains and pen marks — it means you are using it.

SECTION 1

How to Use This Action Plan

Your CIRA scores told you where you stand. This plan tells you what to do next.

Congratulations on completing the Cultural Innovation Readiness Assessment. That alone puts you ahead of most cultural entrepreneurs, because awareness is the first step toward growth. Now comes the part that matters most: turning those insights into action.

This action plan is not a document to read and file away. It is a workbook — a tool for building the specific capabilities your enterprise needs. Every section includes fill-in templates, checklists, and week-by-week action items designed for busy cultural entrepreneurs who need to make progress without putting their day-to-day work on hold.

How to Navigate This Plan

Step 1: Review your CIRA results. Look at your scores across the four dimensions: Cultural Capital Inventory, Innovation Ecosystem, Barriers Assessment, and Readiness Indicators. Identify your weakest dimension — that is where you should start.

Step 2: Go directly to the relevant section. Each of the four dimensions has its own 90-day action plan in Section 2. Start with your lowest-scoring dimension. If two are equally low, start with whichever feels most urgent to your business right now.

Step 3: Complete the diagnostic. Each section opens with a brief diagnostic that helps you understand what a low score in that area really means for your enterprise.

Step 4: Follow the 90-day plan. Each dimension includes a week-by-week plan with specific actions, templates, and milestones. Work through it at your own pace, but aim to complete one full cycle within 90 days.

Step 5: Track your progress. Use the Milestone Tracker in Section 7 to record your progress each week. A 15-minute weekly check-in is all it takes.

TIP: Start Small

You do not need to work on all four dimensions at once. Focus on one for 90 days, then reassess. Sustainable progress beats ambitious burnout every time.

Plan Structure at a Glance

Section	What It Contains	When to Use It
90-Day Action Plans	Week-by-week plans for each CIRA dimension	Start here — go to your weakest dimension
Barrier Matrix	2x2 prioritisation tool for overcoming obstacles	When you feel overwhelmed by challenges
Resource Mapping	Templates for skills, funding, and partnership planning	When planning how to access resources
Skill Gap Analysis	Self-assessment and training planner for 12 key skills	When building team or personal capabilities
Appropriation Risk	Ethical checklist for cultural innovation boundaries	Before launching any new product or innovation
Milestone Tracker	12-week progress tracking template	Every week — your accountability tool

WARNING: Do Not Skip the Diagnostic

It is tempting to jump straight to the action items, but the diagnostic at the start of each section helps you understand the root cause of your score. Without that understanding, you risk treating symptoms rather than causes.

SECTION 2

90-Day Action Plans by Dimension

This section is the heart of the workbook. Each of the four CIRA dimensions gets its own comprehensive 90-day plan. Go directly to the dimension where you scored lowest and begin there.

2a

Cultural Capital Inventory

Diagnostic

If you scored low on Cultural Capital Inventory, it means your enterprise has not yet fully mapped, documented, or assessed the cultural assets it holds. You may be sitting on a wealth of knowledge, traditions, techniques, and relationships — but without a clear inventory, you cannot strategically build on those assets. Undocumented cultural capital is vulnerable capital: it can be lost when a key person leaves, a community disperses, or a generation passes without transferring what it knows.

The good news is that this dimension responds quickly to focused effort. In 90 days, you can move from scattered awareness to a comprehensive, organised register of everything your enterprise holds culturally — and everything it risks losing.

Priority Actions

1. Map all tangible cultural assets. Buildings, workshops, tools, equipment, raw materials, finished products, pattern archives, sample libraries, and any physical objects that carry cultural value.

2. Document intangible assets. Traditional knowledge, craft techniques, songs, stories, oral histories, relationships with communities, seasonal knowledge, spiritual practices connected to the craft, and tacit skills held by master practitioners.

3. Identify asset gaps. What knowledge is at risk of being lost? Which techniques are held by only one person? What materials are becoming scarce? Where are the fragile points in your cultural supply chain?

4. Assess asset quality and condition. Are your tools in working order? Is your documentation accurate and up to date? Are your community relationships strong or strained? What needs repair, renewal, or reinvestment?

5. Create a cultural asset register. Compile everything into a single, organised, accessible document or database that your team and community stakeholders can reference and update.

90-Day Plan: Week by Week

Weeks	Focus Area	Key Activities	Output

1–2	Asset Discovery	Conduct community walks and interviews. Visit workshops, storage areas, sacred sites. List every tangible asset you find. Talk to elders and long-standing community members.	Preliminary asset list (written or photographed)
3–4	Documentation	Photograph all tangible assets. Video-record demonstrations of techniques. Write detailed process descriptions. Create skill maps for key practitioners.	Photo/video archive and written records
5–6	Gap Analysis	Review asset list for single-point-of-failure risks. Identify undocumented techniques. Note materials that are scarce or endangered. List relationships that need strengthening.	Gap analysis report with risk ratings
7–8	Quality Assessment	Evaluate condition of tools and facilities. Assess accuracy of existing documentation. Review strength of community partnerships. Identify what needs repair or renewal.	Quality scorecard for each major asset
9–10	Digital Archive	Organise all photos, videos, and documents. Create a simple digital filing system. Back up everything in at least two locations. Set up a shared access system for team.	Organised digital archive accessible to team
11–12	Asset Register	Compile the complete Cultural Asset Register. Share draft with community for feedback. Incorporate feedback and finalise. Set a review date (every 6 months).	Complete Cultural Asset Register

Cultural Asset Inventory Worksheet

Use this template to catalogue each cultural asset your enterprise holds. Add rows as needed. Be thorough — include everything from major assets (a building, a rare technique) to smaller items (a specific tool, a community recipe, a seasonal calendar).

Asset Name	Type (Tangible/ Intangible)	Current Use	Innovation Potential (1–5)	Sensitivity (Sacred/Flexible/ Open)	Risk Level (High/Med/ Low)
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]
	[T or I]		[1–5]	[S / F / O]	[H / M / L]

Success Metrics

You have improved your Cultural Capital Inventory when:

- You have a complete written register of all tangible cultural assets
- At least 80% of key intangible assets are documented (written, video, or audio)
- No critical technique is held by only one person without documentation
- Your digital archive is organised, backed up, and accessible to your team
- You have identified your top 3 at-risk cultural assets and made plans to protect them
- Community stakeholders have reviewed and validated your asset register

TIP: Interview Template

When interviewing elders or master practitioners, use open questions: 'Tell me about how you learned this technique.' 'What has changed since you began?' 'What do you worry will be lost?' Record with permission and always share the results back with the interviewee.

2b

Innovation Ecosystem

Diagnostic

If you scored low on Innovation Ecosystem, it means your enterprise is too isolated. You may be doing excellent work, but you are not well-connected to the networks, partnerships, markets, mentors, and institutions that could accelerate your growth. Cultural enterprises rarely innovate alone — the most successful ones are embedded in rich ecosystems of support, collaboration, and exchange.

A weak innovation ecosystem means missed opportunities: grants you never hear about, partnerships that could open new markets, technologies that could amplify your craft, and peers who face similar challenges and have already found solutions. Over the next 90 days, you will systematically build the connections your enterprise needs.

Priority Actions

1. Map your current network. List every person, organisation, and institution you currently interact with. Include suppliers, customers, government contacts, NGOs, fellow entrepreneurs, and cultural institutions. Assess the strength and value of each relationship.

2. Identify partnership opportunities. Research organisations, programs, and networks that support cultural enterprises in your region. Look for business development agencies, trade associations, university partnerships, and international cultural networks.

3. Conduct market research. Understand your current and potential markets. Who buys cultural products like yours? Where are they? What do they value? What are they willing to pay? What channels do they use to discover cultural products?

4. Find mentors and advisors. Identify experienced individuals — in cultural enterprise, business, export, marketing, or finance — who could advise you. Look for formal mentorship programs, advisory boards, or informal relationships.

5. Join or create a peer group. Connect with other cultural entrepreneurs facing similar challenges. Peer groups provide emotional support, practical knowledge sharing, collective marketing opportunities, and accountability.

90-Day Plan: Week by Week

Weeks	Focus Area	Key Activities	Output
1–2	Network Mapping	List all current contacts and partners. Rate each relationship (strong/weak/dormant). Identify gaps: who is missing from your network? Research 10 potential new connections.	Network map with gap analysis
3–4	Partnership Research	Research trade associations and cooperatives. Identify 3 potential institutional partners. Attend one networking event (virtual or in-person). Reach out to 5 potential collaborators.	Partnership shortlist with contact details
5–6	Market Intelligence	Survey 20 current or potential customers. Research online marketplaces and platforms. Analyse 5 comparable cultural enterprises. Identify 2–3 new market opportunities.	Market research summary document
7–8	Mentor Search	Identify 5 potential mentors or advisors. Reach out with a clear, specific ask. Apply to 1–2 formal mentorship programs. Schedule at least 2 advisory conversations.	Active mentor relationship(s)
9–10	Peer Group Building	Identify 5–10 peer cultural entrepreneurs. Organise or join a regular meeting (monthly). Establish a shared communication channel. Plan one collaborative activity.	Active peer group with meeting schedule
11–12	Ecosystem Activation	Follow up on all new connections made. Formalise at least one partnership. Create a networking calendar for next quarter. Update your network map with new relationships.	Updated ecosystem map and partnership plan

Network Mapping Template

Use this template to map your current and target ecosystem. For each contact, note their role, the relationship strength, and what you need from them or can offer them.

Contact / Organisation	Type (Supplier / Partner / Mentor / Peer / Funder)	Relation ship Strength (1–5)	What They Offer You	What You Offer Them	Next Action

Success Metrics

You have a documented network map with at least 30 contacts

You have identified and approached at least 3 potential institutional partners

You have completed market research with data from at least 20 customers

You have at least 1 active mentor or advisor relationship

You are part of an active peer group meeting at least monthly

You have a networking plan and calendar for the next quarter

TIP: Quality Over Quantity

Five strong, reciprocal relationships are worth more than fifty business cards. Focus on building genuine connections where both parties benefit. The best partnerships in cultural enterprise are built on mutual respect and shared values, not just transactional needs.

2c

Barriers Assessment

Diagnostic

If you scored high on barriers (or low on barrier management), it means your enterprise faces significant obstacles that are not being effectively addressed. This is common — cultural entrepreneurs face a unique combination of challenges that mainstream business advice rarely covers: financial barriers compounded by cultural preservation costs, regulatory hurdles that do not recognise cultural enterprise as a category, skills gaps in both traditional craft and modern business, and the ever-present tension between protecting heritage and accessing markets.

The key insight here is that not all barriers are equal. Some are quick to remove with the right knowledge. Others require long-term strategic effort. And some are best accepted and worked around rather than fought head-on. Over the next 90 days, you will identify, prioritise, and begin systematically removing the barriers that matter most.

Common Barrier Types for Cultural Enterprises

Barrier Type	Examples	Typical Root Cause
Financial	Lack of startup capital, no access to credit, inability to fund growth, seasonal cash flow gaps	Exclusion from traditional finance; funders do not understand cultural enterprise
Regulatory	No legal category for cultural enterprise, import/export restrictions on cultural goods, IP protection gaps	Policy frameworks designed for industrial, not cultural, economies
Skills	Gaps in digital marketing, financial management, export logistics, or business planning	Training programs focus on either craft OR business, rarely both
Market Access	Inability to reach international buyers, no distribution channels, price competition from mass-produced alternatives	Geographic isolation; lack of networks; low digital presence
Technology	Limited digital tools, no e-commerce capability, no digital documentation of processes	Cost barriers; digital literacy gaps; infrastructure gaps
Cultural Resistance	Community opposition to innovation, generational disagreements about change, fear of cultural dilution	Legitimate concerns about cultural integrity; lack of consultation processes

Appropriation Fear	Reluctance to share knowledge publicly, concerns about designs being copied, resistance to digital documentation	Real history of cultural theft; lack of IP protection mechanisms

Priority Actions

1. List every barrier you face. Be honest and comprehensive. Include barriers that feel uncomfortable to name. Ask your team, your community, and your customers what they see as obstacles.

2. Categorise and prioritise. Use the Barrier Prioritisation Matrix in Section 3 to plot each barrier by impact and effort. This tells you what to tackle first and what to defer.

3. Conduct root cause analysis. For your top 3 barriers, dig deeper. Ask 'Why does this barrier exist?' five times in succession. The answer at the fifth level is usually the real root cause.

4. Develop barrier-removal strategies. For each priority barrier, create a specific plan: what action, by whom, by when, with what resources.

5. Mobilise resources. Identify what you need to remove each barrier: money, skills, connections, time, policy change. Match each need to a potential source.

90-Day Plan: Week by Week

Weeks	Focus Area	Key Activities	Output
1–2	Barrier Identification	Brainstorm all barriers with your team. Survey community members and customers. Review your CIRA scores for specific weaknesses. List barriers across all 7 categories.	Comprehensive barrier list (aim for 15–25 items)
3–4	Prioritisation	Complete the Barrier Prioritisation Matrix. Identify your top 5 barriers by impact. Sort into: Quick Wins, Strategic, Low-hanging, Drop. Select 3 barriers to focus on this quarter.	Prioritised barrier list with top 3 selected
5–6	Root Cause Analysis	Apply the '5 Whys' method to each top barrier. Research how others have overcome similar barriers. Identify systemic vs. enterprise-specific causes. Document findings and insights.	Root cause analysis for top 3 barriers
7–8	Strategy Development	For each barrier, define 2–3 removal strategies. Assess feasibility and resource requirements. Select the most promising strategy for each. Create action plans with timelines.	Barrier-removal strategy documents
9–10	Resource Mobilisation	Identify resources needed for each strategy. Apply for relevant grants or support programs. Reach out to potential partners or advisors. Begin implementing Quick Win strategies.	Resource plan and initial progress on Quick Wins

11–12	Progress Review	Assess progress on barrier removal. Document what worked and what did not. Adjust strategies as needed. Plan next quarter's barrier focus areas.	Progress report and next-quarter plan

Barrier Identification Worksheet

Barrier Description	Category	Impact (1–5)	Effort to Remove (1–5)	Priority (H / M / L)

Success Metrics

You have a comprehensive list of at least 15 barriers across multiple categories

Your barriers are prioritised using the matrix and you have selected your top 3

You have completed root cause analysis for your top 3 barriers

You have a written strategy for removing or mitigating each top barrier

At least 1 Quick Win barrier has been resolved or significantly reduced

You have identified specific resources needed for longer-term barrier removal

WARNING: Cultural Resistance Is Not Always a Barrier

If community members are resisting an innovation, pause before classifying this as a 'barrier to overcome.' Their concerns may be legitimate guardianship of cultural integrity. Always investigate the reason for resistance before trying to remove it. Sometimes the barrier is telling you something important about the boundaries of appropriate innovation.

2d

Readiness Indicators

Diagnostic

If you scored low on Readiness Indicators, it means your enterprise has the cultural assets and perhaps even the ambition to innovate, but lacks the internal capabilities to execute effectively. Think of it this way: you have the raw materials (cultural capital) and perhaps the blueprint (innovation ideas), but the workshop itself — your leadership, systems, skills, technology, and financial planning — is not yet equipped for the work ahead.

Low readiness is the most common reason cultural innovations fail to move from idea to market. It is also the most fixable dimension, because it responds directly to deliberate capacity building. Over the next 90 days, you will audit your internal capabilities, fill the most critical gaps, and build the systems that make innovation sustainable rather than accidental.

Priority Actions

1. Audit leadership and decision-making. Who leads innovation in your enterprise? Is there a clear decision-making process for trying new things? Do team members feel empowered to suggest ideas? Is there a culture of learning from failure?

2. Conduct a team skills audit. Map the skills your team has against the skills your enterprise needs. Include both craft/cultural skills and business skills (marketing, finance, digital, logistics). Identify the critical gaps.

3. Review financial planning. Do you have a budget for innovation? Can you invest in experiments that may not pay off immediately? Do you have financial reserves to weather a failed product launch? Is your bookkeeping strong enough to track innovation costs?

4. Assess technology readiness. What digital tools do you currently use? What do you need? Consider: e-commerce, social media, digital design, inventory management, accounting software, communication tools. Rate your team's digital confidence.

5. Build measurement systems. Can you track sales by product? Do you know your cost per unit? Can you measure customer satisfaction? Do you have baseline data to compare against future innovations? Without measurement, you cannot manage.

90-Day Plan: Week by Week

Weeks	Focus Area	Key Activities	Output
1–2	Leadership Audit	Assess current decision-making processes. Identify innovation champions on your team. Review how past innovation attempts were handled. Define clear roles for innovation leadership.	Leadership assessment and role assignments
3–4	Skills Audit	Complete the Skill Gap Analysis (Section 5). Map team strengths and weaknesses. Identify top 3 critical skill gaps. Research training options for each gap.	Completed skill gap analysis with training plan
5–6	Financial Planning	Review current financial systems and records. Create an innovation budget (even a small one). Estimate costs of planned innovations. Identify funding sources for capacity building.	Innovation budget and financial improvement plan
7–8	Technology Adoption	Audit current technology use. Research tools that match your needs and budget. Train team on 1–2 new tools. Set up basic digital infrastructure.	Technology roadmap and initial adoption
9–10	Market Testing Capability	Design a simple process for testing new ideas. Run one low-cost market test. Create a template for rapid prototyping. Document the testing process for future use.	Market testing process and one completed test
11–12	Measurement Systems	Set up basic data collection for sales and costs. Establish baseline metrics for key indicators. Create a simple dashboard or tracking sheet. Schedule regular review sessions.	Measurement system and baseline data

Innovation Readiness Self-Check

Rate your enterprise on each dimension below. Be honest — this is for your planning, not for anyone else.

Readiness Area	Current Level (1–5)	Where You Need to Be (1–5)	Gap (Difference)	Priority (H / M / L)
Innovation leadership				
Team craft/cultural skills				
Team business skills				
Financial management				
Digital/technology capability				
Market knowledge				
Data and measurement				
Risk tolerance / learning culture				

Success Metrics

Clear innovation leadership roles are defined and understood by the team

Top 3 skill gaps have training plans in progress

An innovation budget exists, even if small

At least 1 new digital tool has been adopted and is in regular use

You have run at least 1 structured market test

Basic measurement systems are in place for sales, costs, and customer feedback

TIP: Innovation Budget Does Not Need to Be Big

Even setting aside 5% of revenue for experimentation makes a difference. The point is not the amount — it is the mindset. When innovation has its own budget line, it becomes a deliberate activity rather than something you try to squeeze in when there is time and money left over.

SECTION 3

Barrier Prioritisation Matrix

Not all barriers deserve equal attention. This matrix helps you sort your barriers into four categories based on two factors: the impact of removing the barrier on your enterprise, and the effort required to remove it. The goal is to focus your limited time and resources where they will make the biggest difference.

How to Use the Matrix

Step 1: List all the barriers you identified in Section 2c.

Step 2: Rate each barrier on Impact (how much would removing it improve your enterprise?) on a scale of 1–5.

Step 3: Rate each barrier on Effort (how much time, money, and energy is needed to remove it?) on a scale of 1–5.

Step 4: Plot each barrier in the appropriate quadrant below.

Step 5: Follow the decision rules for each quadrant.

	LOW EFFORT to Remove (1–2)	**HIGH EFFORT to Remove (3–5)**
HIGH IMPACT (3–5)	QUICK WINS Do these FIRST. Maximum return, minimum investment. [Write your Quick Wins here]	STRATEGIC PROJECTS Plan carefully. High return but requires investment. [Write your Strategic Projects here]
LOW IMPACT (1–2)	LOW-HANGING FRUIT Delegate or do when you have spare time. Nice to resolve, not urgent. [Write your Low-hanging Fruit here]	DROP / DEFER Ignore for now. Not worth the effort for the return. [Write your Deferred Barriers here]

Worked Example

Here is how a fictional textile cooperative in Guatemala used the matrix:

Barrier	Impact	Effort	Quadrant	Decision
No e-commerce presence	5	2	Quick Win	Set up Etsy shop this month
No access to export finance	4	5	Strategic	Apply for 2 programs this quarter
Outdated packaging design	2	1	Low-hanging	Intern to redesign next month
Government craft certification process takes 18 months	3	5	Drop / Defer	Accept and work around it
Dyes fade in washing	5	3	Strategic	Research and test new fixatives
No social media presence	4	1	Quick Win	Start Instagram this week

TIP: Review Quarterly

Your barriers will shift over time. Some will be removed, new ones will emerge, and the relative importance of others will change. Revisit this matrix every 90 days as part of your planning cycle.

SECTION 4

Resource Mapping Worksheet

Every barrier you face and every capability you want to build requires resources: skills, money, partnerships, and time. This section provides three mapping templates to help you identify what you have, what you need, and where to find it.

4a. Skills Map

Map the skills your enterprise needs against the skills your team currently has. This reveals your most critical gaps and helps you plan training and recruitment.

Skill Needed	Current Level (1–5)	Who Has It?	How to Build It	Timeline
Core craft technique				
Digital marketing				
Financial management				
E-commerce / online sales				
Export logistics				
Product photography				
Intellectual property law				
Community facilitation				
Grant writing				
Product design/development				
Quality control				
Storytelling and branding				

4b. Funding Map

Map your funding needs against potential sources. Cross-reference with the CIL Global Funding Guide for specific grant opportunities in your region and sector.

Funding Need	Amount Needed	Potential Sources	Application Deadline	Status [Not started / In progress / Applied]

4c. Partnership Map

Map the partnerships your enterprise needs to grow. Think broadly: suppliers, distributors, government agencies, NGOs, universities, media outlets, and cultural institutions all play roles in a healthy innovation ecosystem.

Partner Type	Specific Organisation	Contact Person	Relationship Status	Next Action
Suppliers			[New / Developing / Established]	
Distributors			[New / Developing / Established]	
Government			[New / Developing / Established]	
NGOs / Foundations			[New / Developing / Established]	
Universities / Research			[New / Developing / Established]	
Media			[New / Developing / Established]	
Cultural Institutions			[New / Developing / Established]	
Fellow Enterprises			[New / Developing / Established]	

TIP: Think in Reciprocity

The strongest partnerships are mutual. For every organisation you list, write down not just what they can do for you, but what you can offer them. Cultural enterprises often underestimate their value to academic researchers, tourism agencies, and brand partners.

SECTION 5

Skill Gap Analysis & Training Planner

Cultural enterprises need a unique blend of skills: deep cultural knowledge and craft mastery alongside modern business capabilities. Most training programs address one or the other, rarely both. This tool helps you assess where you stand across 12 key skill areas and plan your development pathway.

Self-Assessment Rubric

Rate yourself or your team honestly on each skill. Use the scoring guide below.

Score	Level	What It Means
1	No Capability	You have no skills or experience in this area and would not know where to start.
2	Basic Awareness	You understand the concept but have not practised it. You could follow simple instructions.
3	Developing	You have some experience and can handle basic tasks, but need guidance for complex work.
4	Competent	You can handle most tasks independently and produce good results consistently.
5	Expert	You have deep expertise, could teach others, and can handle complex or novel challenges.

Skills Assessment Grid

Skill Area	Your Score (1–5)	Target Score	Gap	Priority (H/M/L)	Training Plan
Traditional craft mastery					
Cultural knowledge and history					
Product development and design					

Financial management and bookkeeping					
Marketing and branding					
Digital tools and e-commerce					
Customer service and communication					
Supply chain and logistics					
Grant writing and fundraising					
Intellectual property and legal basics					
Community engagement and facilitation					
Leadership and team management					

Training Resources by Skill Area

Below are recommended learning pathways for each skill gap. Start with free resources. Move to paid options when you need deeper, structured learning.

Skill Area	Free Resources	Paid Options
Financial management	Khan Academy; Wave accounting (free software); GlobalGiving financial literacy modules	Local business development center workshops; Coursera business courses
Digital marketing	Google Digital Garage; HubSpot Academy; Canva Design School; YouTube tutorials	Hootsuite Academy; local digital skills bootcamps
E-commerce	Shopify Academy; Etsy Seller Handbook; platform-specific tutorials	Craft business online courses; local tech incubator programs
Grant writing	Candid (Foundation Center) free courses; CIL Global Funding Guide; YouTube	CIL Premium Grant Writing Toolkit; local nonprofit management courses
IP and legal	WIPO free online courses; Creative Commons resources; national IP office guides	IP lawyer consultation; specialised cultural IP workshops
Photography	iPhone Photography School (free tips); YouTube lighting tutorials; Canva blog	Skillshare; local photography workshops; CIL Premium Brand Toolkit

Mentorship Matching Guidance

A good mentor can accelerate your learning faster than any course. When seeking mentors, look for people who combine cultural understanding with business experience. The best mentors for cultural entrepreneurs are often those who have successfully navigated the same tension between heritage and market that you face. Check with local chambers of commerce, cultural councils, university outreach programs, and organisations like Ashoka, Endeavor, or Acumen for formal mentorship matching. If formal programs are unavailable in your area, approach successful cultural entrepreneurs in adjacent sectors and propose a quarterly advisory conversation over coffee.

SECTION 6

Cultural Appropriation Risk Assessment

Innovation in cultural enterprise carries a unique responsibility: ensuring that the communities who hold cultural knowledge are respected, credited, and compensated. This checklist helps you assess whether a proposed innovation crosses ethical lines — before you invest time and money into it. Use it every time you develop a new product, enter a new market, or form a new partnership.

The Traffic Light System

Colour	Meaning	Action
GREEN	All clear. Your innovation respects cultural boundaries, involves community consent, and includes benefit-sharing.	Proceed with confidence. Document your process for transparency.
AMBER	Caution needed. Some aspects of your innovation may raise concerns. Specific risks have been identified.	Proceed with modifications. Address flagged concerns before launching.
RED	Stop and reconsider. Significant cultural integrity risks have been identified. The innovation may cause harm.	Do not proceed as planned. Redesign with community input or abandon.

Cultural Integrity Checklist

For each question, answer honestly. A 'No' answer in any section moves your overall assessment toward Amber or Red.

CONSENT

Have you consulted the community or cultural custodians who hold this knowledge?

Have they given informed, freely-given consent for this specific use of the cultural element?

Is there a documented agreement about how the cultural knowledge can be used?

CONTEXT

Does your innovation preserve the cultural meaning and context of the original element?

Would members of the source community recognise and approve of how their culture is represented?

Are you avoiding the use of sacred or ceremonial elements for commercial purposes without explicit permission?

CREDIT

Is the cultural origin of your product clearly acknowledged in all marketing and packaging?

Are specific communities, artisans, or knowledge holders named and credited where appropriate?

Does your branding avoid implying that the cultural innovation is your original creation?

COMPENSATION

Do community members or cultural custodians receive fair financial compensation?

Is there a written agreement about revenue sharing or benefit distribution?

Are artisans and knowledge holders paid rates that reflect the true value of their cultural skills?

COMMUNITY BENEFIT

Does the innovation strengthen the source community (economically, socially, or culturally)?

Is the community involved in decision-making about how the innovation evolves?

Will the innovation help preserve and transmit cultural knowledge to future generations?

Scoring Your Assessment

All 15 boxes checked: GREEN — Proceed with confidence.

12–14 boxes checked: AMBER — Address the unchecked items before proceeding.

Fewer than 12 boxes checked: RED — Significant redesign needed. Consult with community before moving forward.

Any 'No' in the Consent section: Automatic RED — Do not proceed without community consent.

If You Identify a Risk

Step 1: Pause the project. Do not launch or invest further until the risk is addressed.

Step 2: Consult with the affected community directly. Listen without defending your idea.

Step 3: Redesign the innovation to address the specific concern. This might mean changing the product, adjusting benefit-sharing, adding cultural context, or in some cases, deciding not to proceed.

Step 4: Document the process and outcome. This builds trust with communities and creates a reference for future decisions.

WARNING: Cultural Appropriation Is Not Just About Intent

Even with the best intentions, innovation can cause cultural harm if the process does not centre community voice. Good intentions do not replace good process. This checklist is about process, not just intent.

SECTION 7

Milestone Tracker

Progress happens in small steps. This tracker helps you stay accountable with a simple weekly check-in. Set aside 15 minutes every Friday afternoon (or whatever day works for you) to review your week, note what you accomplished, and set your priority for the next week.

Weekly Check-In Instructions

Each week, answer three questions:

1. What did I plan to do this week? (Refer to your 90-day plan)
2. What did I actually accomplish? (Be honest — partial progress counts)
3. What is my single most important priority for next week?

12-Week Milestone Tracker

Week	Planned Action	Completed (Y / N / Partial)	Notes / Learnings	Next Week Priority
Week 1				
Week 2				
Week 3				
Week 4				
Week 5				
Week 6				
Week 7				
Week 8				
Week 9				
Week 10				
Week 11				
Week 12				

End-of-Quarter Reflection

At the end of your 90-day cycle, take 30 minutes to reflect on your overall progress. Answer these questions honestly:

What was my biggest achievement this quarter?

[describe your most meaningful accomplishment]

What was my biggest challenge, and how did I handle it?

[describe the challenge and your response]

What would I do differently next quarter?

[identify adjustments for next cycle]

What CIRA dimension should I focus on next?

[based on your progress, choose your next focus area]

What support do I need that I do not currently have?

[mentors, funding, skills, partnerships, tools]

Remember: Progress is not perfection. If you completed even half of what you planned, you are further ahead than you were 90 days ago. Celebrate that. Then plan the next 90 days.

TIP: Retake Your CIRA Assessment

After completing a full 90-day cycle, retake the CIRA assessment on the CIL platform. Comparing your new scores with your original ones will show you exactly how much progress you have made — and where to focus next. Recommended frequency: every 6–12 months.

You Can Do This.

Cultural innovation is not about abandoning what you know. It is about building on it with intention, skill, and community support. Every master artisan, every cultural leader, every heritage entrepreneur who came before you faced the same question you face today: how do I honour the past while building a future? This plan gives you the structure to answer that question — one week at a time.

Start where you are. Use what you have. Do what you can.

CULTURAL INNOVATION LAB

www.culturalinnovationlab.org

This resource is part of the CIL platform suite. For assessments, tools, and community, visit us online.

© 2025-2026 Cultural Innovation Lab. All rights reserved.